

Special Interest Group: Evaluating Research From and About the Global Majority

Farhana Shahid*
Information Science
Cornell University
Ithaca, New York, USA
fs468@cornell.edu

Hellina Hailu Nigatu*
EECS
UC Berkeley
Berkeley, California, USA
hellina_nigatu@berkeley.edu

Syed Ishtiaque Ahmed
Computer Science
University of Toronto
Toronto, Ontario, Canada
ishtiaque@cs.toronto.edu

Michaelanne Thomas
School of Information
University of Michigan
Ann Arbor, Michigan, USA
mmtd@umich.edu

Abigail Oppong
Ashesi University
Berekuso, Ghana
abigoppong@gmail.com

Abstract

CSCW and HCI research from and about the Global Majority is often misunderstood and undervalued in the current academic review processes. This SIG invites collective discussion on the often-overlooked issue of how the review process affects collective knowledge production about Global Majority communities. By centering the experiences of researchers working in the Global Majority, we aim to highlight the power dynamics and normative assumptions about non-WEIRD research subjects and researchers. We are an interdisciplinary group driven by concerns about equity, structural discrimination, and global disparities in knowledge production, and we hope to find solutions to these challenges. Through our SIG, we aspire to explore strategies to address WEIRD assumptions in the review process and co-learn with fellow researchers on how positionality affects the review process for and about the Global Majority.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *Human computer interaction (HCI)*.

Keywords

power, critical HCI, peer review, Global Majority

ACM Reference Format:

Farhana Shahid, Hellina Hailu Nigatu, Syed Ishtiaque Ahmed, Michaelanne Thomas, and Abigail Oppong. 2025. Special Interest Group: Evaluating Research From and About the Global Majority. In *Companion of the Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW Companion '25)*, October 18–22, 2025, Bergen, Norway. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3715070.3748280>

*Both authors contributed equally to this research.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).
CSCW Companion '25, Bergen, Norway
© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).
ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1480-1/25/10
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3715070.3748280>

1 Introduction

Historically, research presented at HCI and other interdisciplinary venues has been predominantly produced by, and centered on, Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) societies [9, 13]. While prior scholarship has highlighted the logistical, epistemic, and infrastructural challenges faced by HCI researchers from the Global Majority [8], less attention has been paid to the structural biases embedded in the peer review process.

Prior research reveals that academic publishing—and peer review in particular—remains largely structured around Western norms and institutions, often leading to the gatekeeping and marginalization of scholars from the Global Majority [2]. These biases are evident in several ways, including an undue emphasis on English language proficiency over intellectual or scientific contribution [12], and pervasive assumptions that research from the Global Majority institutions is inherently of lower quality compared to the work produced in Western contexts [7]. Consequently, research from non-WEIRD regions face disparities in citation and reduced visibility [10].

In this uneven terrain of knowledge production, Western scholars and institutions continue to dominate the research landscape [6]. However, researchers from the Global Majority often bring historically overlooked perspectives that can widen our overall understanding of computing and its impact. Yet, these contributions are often undervalued in the current peer review process. Our offline exchanges with fellow researchers show that reviewers often hold implicit expectations that HCI research from the Global Majority should be “exotic”, “different”, and at the same time, “generalizable”. Further, studies conducted in Global Majority contexts are often dismissed as lacking novelty when similar phenomena have been previously documented in Western settings. Authors are often compelled to justify the relevance of studying particular issues in their local contexts, particularly when reviewers operate under the assumption that Global Majority contexts are too “niche” to warrant scholarly attention. Furthermore, ethnographic and qualitative inquiries that surface culturally specific insights are often rejected on the grounds of insufficient contribution, disregarding the epistemic value of localized knowledge [11].

Such rejections not only devalue the lived experiences of communities in the Global Majority, but also fail to account for the

historical and cultural contexts—often shaped by colonial legacies—in which the research is situated. Moreover, reviewers' comments sometimes include implicit biases that question the legitimacy of authors from non-Western institutions, such as suggesting the need for a "*native English speaker*" to review or co-author the submission [12]. These practices contribute to a broader system of epistemic exclusion, reinforcing hierarchical power dynamics and limiting the ability of marginalized scholars to contest reviewer assumptions. Over time, such norms become institutionalized within the review process, further entrenching the marginalization of Global Majority scholarship within HCI.

Despite the widespread and recurring nature of these exclusionary experiences, they remain largely undocumented in formal academic discourse. Conversations around unjust peer review practices tend to be relegated to informal, often private exchanges—whether in offline settings or online forums. As a result, there are limited opportunities for systemic critique and collective reflection within the broader HCI and CSCW community. Organizers of this SIG convened after repeated, separate negative experiences with academic review in publishing CSCW and HCI research on and about the Global Majority. As a group of interdisciplinary researchers who want to create an equitable space for ourselves and others who study and are from Global Majority communities, we aim to create a co-learning space where the informal conversations about WEIRD reviewing assumptions regarding Global Majority are converted to actionable tasks.

We believe these issues speak directly to core CSCW concerns, including the politics of knowledge production [1], the design of equitable sociotechnical systems [5], and the collaborative processes that underlie scholarly practice itself [3]. As peer review is a fundamental form of collaborative work within the research community, understanding how it reproduces or resists global power asymmetries in knowledge production is critical. By interrogating how review mechanisms may marginalize certain epistemologies, and by proposing more inclusive alternatives, this SIG contributes to ongoing conversations in CSCW about justice, reflexivity, and global inclusivity in research practice [4].

2 Structure and Goal of the SIG

This SIG aims to convene researchers from the Global Majority alongside those based in Western contexts to reflect on how prevailing peer review practices impact the production and recognition of knowledge emerging from Global Majority contexts. By enabling open dialogue among authors, reviewers, and paper chairs, we seek to illuminate how entrenched epistemic norms—often aligned with WEIRD paradigms—can marginalize research grounded in different sociocultural realities.

Through participatory discussions and reflective prompts, the SIG will create a space for sharing lived experiences with peer review processes that may unintentionally reproduce epistemic injustices. Two key probes will guide the conversation: (1) strategies for Global Majority researchers to respond to and resist problematic assumptions embedded in peer reviews, and (2) guidance for reviewers on how to engage with Global Majority research in a manner that is methodologically rigorous, contextually informed, and ethically attuned.

We will distill the insights shared during the session and share our insights either in the form of an article or a blog post following the SIG. This documentation will offer actionable recommendations for fostering a more inclusive, equitable peer review culture within HCI and CSCW communities. The SIG will be in-person and follow Chatham house rules to facilitate free information sharing while ensuring the anonymity of the speakers. Following is a tentative breakdown of the activities planned to utilize the 90 minute duration of the SIG.

- *Introduction* (10 minutes): We will go around the room, where organizers and participants will briefly introduce themselves (e.g., name, affiliation, and research engagement with Global Majority).
- *Shared Experiences* (20 minutes): We will try to divide the room in two groups, where each group will share if they encountered problematic reviewing assumptions in their work on/ from the Global Majority and why they found it problematic. Organizing members will join the conversation in each group and take notes following Chatham house rule. One organizing member will do timekeeping and nudge the groups so that everyone gets to share their experiences and wrap up in time.
- *Strategies to Resist* (20 minutes): Based on the shared experiences, participants in each group will brainstorm potential strategies/ the challenges to resist problematic reviewing assumptions about research on/ from the Global Majority. Organizing members will again take notes and do timekeeping.
- *Educating the Community* (20 minutes): Among the participants, those who have experience as reviewers or as paper/program chairs will be encouraged to share their reflections on the review process for research about or originating from the Global Majority. All group members will be encouraged to discuss ways to better support and inform peer reviewing to ensure fair evaluation of research from the Global Majority. Organizers will take notes and ensure timekeeping.
- *Present to the Room* (10 + 5 minutes): Each group will get 5 minutes to present their key takeaways around shared experiences, strategies to resist, and educating the community. There will be additional 5 minutes to answer any questions and comments from the room.
- *Wrap up* (5 minutes): The organizers will wrap up, thank all the participants, and outline how the discussions will be synthesized for broader dissemination within CSCW and HCI community to increase the impact of our conversation.

3 Organizer Bios

Farhana Shahid is a PhD candidate in the Information Science department at Cornell University. She completed her Bachelor's and Master's in Computer Science from Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology. Farhana examines how cultural biases and systemic issues in content moderation systems affect the Global Majority populations and designs culturally-aware alternatives to address online harms.

Hellina Hailu Nigatu is a PhD candidate at the University of California, Berkeley, in the EECS department. She finished her undergrad at Addis Ababa University, Ethiopia in Electrical and Computer Engineering and received her Masters of Science in CS from UC Berkeley in 2023. Hellina's research looks into making NLP tools usable and accessible for languages with limited data, especially for communities in the Global Majority.

Syed Ishtiaque Ahmed is an Associate Professor of Computer Science at the University of Toronto and the founding director of the "Third Space" research group. His research interest is in the intersection between Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and Artificial Intelligence (AI). Ahmed received his PhD and Masters from Cornell University in the USA, and his Bachelor's and Master's from BUET in Bangladesh. In the last fifteen years, he studied and developed successful computing technologies with various marginalized communities in Bangladesh, India, Canada, USA, Pakistan, Iraq, Turkey, and Ecuador.

Dr. Michaelanne Thomas is an Assistant Professor in the School of Information at the University of Michigan where she directs the Anthropology & Technology Lab (ATL) research group. A sociotechnical anthropologist, Thomas and her students use ethnographic methods to explore how communities at the margins collaboratively design and engage with information communication technologies (ICTs) for survival and social change. Thomas's work investigates the issues of power and privilege that are often hidden in most celebratory embraces of grassroots innovation. Her primary field site is Havana, Cuba, where she has been investigating the collaborative creation of internet ecosystems since 2014.

Abigail Oppong is a consultant and independent researcher based in Ghana, focused on democratizing AI for low-resourced communities through a Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) lens. She received her BSc in Information Systems from Ashesi University, Ghana. Her work centers on designing inclusive, culturally relevant technologies that address structural biases in AI systems, particularly in natural language processing and public health—to emphasize local language inclusion, trust, and community participation.

4 Technical Requirements

We will need at least three-four microphones for the speakers. We will need an HDMI and a screen to display the SIG outlines, for timekeeping, and for participants to present their key learnings.

References

- [1] Leah Hope Ajmani, Jasmine C. Foriest, Jordan Taylor, Kyle Pittman, Sarah Gilbert, and Michael Ann DeVito. 2024. Whose Knowledge is Valued? Epistemic Injustice in CSCW Applications. *Proc. ACM Hum.-Comput. Interact.* 8, CSCW2, Article 523 (Nov. 2024), 28 pages.
- [2] Juliana A Bol, Ashley Sheffel, Nukhba Zia, and Ankita Meghani. 2023. How to address the geographical bias in academic publishing. *BMJ Global Health* 8, 12 (2023).
- [3] António Correia, Shoaib Jameel, Daniel Schneider, Benjamim Fonseca, and Hugo Paredes. 2019. The effect of scientific collaboration on CSCW research: A scientometric study. In *2019 IEEE 23rd International Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work in Design (CSCWD)*. IEEE, 129–134.
- [4] Sarah Fox, Jill Dimond, Lilly Irani, Tad Hirsch, Michael Muller, and Shaowen Bardzell. 2017. Social Justice and Design: Power and oppression in collaborative systems. In *Companion of the 2017 ACM Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (Portland, Oregon, USA) (CSCW '17 Companion)*. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 117–122.
- [5] Christina Harrington, Sheena Erete, and Anne Marie Piper. 2019. Deconstructing community-based collaborative design: Towards more equitable participatory design engagements. *Proceedings of the ACM on human-computer interaction* 3, CSCW (2019), 1–25.
- [6] William Held, Camille Harris, Michael Best, and Diyi Yang. 2023. A Material Lens on Coloniality in NLP. *arXiv* (Nov. 2023). doi:10.48550/arXiv.2311.08391 arXiv:2311.08391
- [7] Abhinandan Kulal, Abhishek N, P Shareena, and Sahana Dinesh. 2025. Unmasking Favoritism and Bias in Academic Publishing: An Empirical Study on Editorial Practices. *Public Integrity* (2025), 1–22.
- [8] Neha Kumar, Susan M. Dray, Christian Sturm, Nithya Sambasivan, Laura S. Gaytán-Lugo, Leonel V. Morales Diaz, Negin Dahya, and Nova Ahmed. 2017. HCI Across Borders. In *Proceedings of the 2017 CHI Conference Extended Abstracts on Human Factors in Computing Systems (Denver, Colorado, USA) (CHI EA '17)*. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 3065–3072.
- [9] Sebastian Linxen, Christian Sturm, Florian Brühlmann, Vincent Cassau, Klaus Opwis, and Katharina Reinecke. 2021. How WEIRD is CHI?. In *Proceedings of the 2021 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (Yokohama, Japan) (CHI '21)*. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, Article 143, 14 pages.
- [10] Gabriel Nakamura, Bruno Eleres Soares, Valério D Pillar, José Alexandre Felizola Diniz-Filho, and Leandro Duarte. 2023. Three pathways to better recognize the expertise of Global South researchers. *npj Biodiversity* 2, 1 (2023), 17.
- [11] Soden Robert, Toombs Austin, and Thomas Michaelanne. 2024. Evaluating Interpretive Research in HCI. *Interactions* (Jan. 2024). <https://dl.acm-org.libproxy.berkeley.edu/doi/10.1145/3633200>
- [12] Adriana L Romero-Olivares. 2019. Reviewers, don't be rude to nonnative English speakers. *Science* 3, 10 (2019).
- [13] Ali Akbar Septiandri, Marios Constantinides, Mohammad Tahaei, and Daniele Quercia. 2023. WEIRD FAccTs: How Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic is FAccT?. In *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (Chicago, IL, USA) (FAccT '23)*. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 160–171.